THE CHEETAH'S INDIAN RUN



ALAMY

1947 The last recorded cheetah hunt is reported from the princely state of Korea in modern-day Chhattisgarh. Three cheetahs were shot by the then-ruler Ramanuj Pratap Singh Deo

1952 The cheetah is declared extinct in India, making it the only large mammal to be officially declared extinct in independent India so far

1972 India considers introducing Asiatic cheetahs from Iran. The project falls through after the Shah of Iran is deposed

2008 A proposal is submitted to the Union government to bring in cheetahs from Africa

2009 Kuno Palpur and Nauradehi in MP and Shahgarh in Rajasthan are identified as potential cheetah introduction sites. Cheetah experts from across the world meet in Gajner, Rajasthan, to deliberate on introducing the African cheetah in India. A task force is constituted under Project Cheetah

2012 The Supreme Court stays the Cheetah Introduction Project while hearing a petition on the translocation of Asiatic lions from Gir to Kuno Palpur

2013 The apex court quashes the introduction plan, terming it arbitrary and illegal

2019 NTCA files an application in the SC seeking clarification of the 2013 order

Jan. 2020 The apex court clears the project

2021 Feasibility studies are carried out again in MP and Rajasthan for the introduction of the cheetah in the immediate future

large cats after one year qualifies as success. And since 12 of the 20 adult cheetahs and 12 of the 17 cubs born on Indian soil have survived, the government counts the project as an achievement. "The project has seen unprecedented success in the birth of cubs in comparison to similar projects in other countries," Yadav tells INDIA TODAY. "These are wild animals, and the initial years of any reintroduction/ conservation translocation project will undergo ebbs as well as flows before stabilising. It is a process of continuous learning, understanding and adapting, not only for the project but also for the cheetahs."

Rajesh Gopal, chairman of the high-level CPSC set up in 2023 to manage the project, echoes the Union minister's thoughts. "The last two years have been eventful, but these are teething troubles," he says. In another marker of the project's 'success', 'The annual progress report on bringing back the cheetah to India', released by the MP forest department recently, claims that the cheetahs have successfully managed to coexist with endemic large carnivores (such as leopards) during the limited time that some of them roamed the wild.

Bengaluru-based wildlife biologist and conservation scientist Ravi Chellam's overriding concern is the continued captivity of the African cheetahs, which violates Namibian regulations that render a cheetah kept in captivity for longer than 90 days unfit for release in the wild. "Their fitness and ability to hunt and survive diminishes. If the period of captivity exceeds 90 days, the cats must either be euthanised or remain permanently captive," he says. "The average home range of an adult female cheetah is 750 sq. km while the average size of the enclosure (boma), where they have been kept for most of the past two years, is less than 1 sq. km. Chital are released in the bomas for 'hunting' by the cheetahs and their diet is supplemented by buffalo meat." Chellam also highlights that at least two of the Namibian cheetahs and the surviving 12 cubs, the youngest of which is about six months old, have never ranged in the wild.

The minister, however, claims it is factually incorrect to say that all cheetahs were in fencing for the past two years. "The cheetahs were intermittently free-ranging. They were brought back into the enclosures for specific health reasons and veterinary treatment. The enclosures are large natural forested areas with wild prey which the cheetahs hunt themselves like in the wild," he says. The cubs are growing in this environment and, in some cases, accompany the mothers on their hunts, he adds. "The transition into free-ranging conditions after a few months when the cubs are older is likely to be a smooth one but, in the wild, one can never really be sure. One cub, who was abandoned by the mother, has been successfully hand-reared and is learning to hunt in the wild. With the help of cheetah experts, the cub will be rehabilitated into the wild," Yadav says.

"Wilding," says Y.V. Jhala, former dean of the Wildlife Institute of India (WII) and principal scientist of the Cheetah Project (2009–2023), "is going to be a long process. We need to be persistent and continue to supplement to allow establishment of free-ranging cheetahs. Mortalities may also occur, and one should not be scared of it." Jhala has called the NTCA's recent decision to release two cheetahs into the wild "very good news".